



"I love the user friendly tutorials and wizards that software have incorporated today. This makes it easy for anyone to accomplish tasks."

—**Karina Noble**
A teacher of Indian origin in Canada



"I just want software that does not crash and gets the job done quickly and efficiently."

—**Loveleen Pasricha**
Sr. Image Manager, Media Solutions, New Delhi



"I use Picasa for pictures and iTunes for music. Anything that's easy to use is good software."

—**Harshini Shah**
a Client Service Executive, Maximus, Mumbai



"We professionals have no problems, but software should be designed to make it easier for those new to technology—men or women."

—**Diana McGowan**
Executive Director, Education Abroad, Australia



"Software should be easy to use. The whole software industry has a long way to go, when it comes to easy adoption for the masses."

—**Romasha Roy Choudhury**
Business Director, Cynapse, Mumbai

that there just isn't enough justification left to continue telling them. Today, hordes of both men and women are employed in the BPO / services industry, and more often than not, when you dial a helpline, you get a woman on the other end helping you with your problem. It makes us wonder whether the women in this industry tell jokes about technology-challenged male callers!

When they require help with something tech-related, most of those we quizzed admitted to using one of three solutions: dialling the manufacturer's helpline, using the age-old dial-a-geek-friend service, or searching online for help. Of the three, looking for solutions online is the least popular, and most had male geek friends on speed-dial. However, this happens to only be true about PC troubleshooting. Purchase decisions are a completely different matter.

Buying Advice

When it comes to buying PCs most admitted to asking friends or family for help—mostly males. Some just depend on their system assembler, or base buying decisions on ads. For laptops, the general consensus is that branded products cannot be bad anyway, so you're pretty safe just buying the latest model that falls within your budget. Most owned Core Duo- or Core 2 Duo-based laptops, with Windows XP being the most popular, but quite a few were running Windows Vista.

The scenario is quite different when buying personal products such as cell phones or MP3 players. Harshini says, "I'm usually the one who gives buying advice to my female friends. If I need advice myself, I generally speed-dial one of my male geek buddies, because none of my women friends know much more than me about technology."

Karina Noble prefers to follow her own decisions, as does Mousumi Chatterji, a technical writer at LionBridge, Mumbai. Mousumi says, "I try and buy things on my own, and do the necessary research. I don't want to end up blaming someone else if I don't like what I buy." A colleague of Mousumi, Sharada Menon, also prefers to buy things on her own after visiting the manufacturer's Web site and looking for features and reviews online.

Interesting here is the fact that most of the women insisted that they weren't rash or impulsive shoppers—not for technology, that is. They preferred to first read about the product, ask either friends who already owned the same model, and even spend as much as an hour with the gadget (most often a mobile phone) at the retail outlet before putting any money down.

Net Anywhere

Quite a few of those we polled used their mobile service providers for Net access when away from their desks. GPRS seems to be the favoured protocol. When asked what they do online, 95 per cent of the answers contained the word "chat." Most of the ladies have Yahoo!, MSN, or Google Talk. Social networking is popular; Orkut and Facebook account for most of the surfing bandwidth.

Other activities involve using the PC for work, researching things for their respective jobs, playing games.... Mousumi says, "I am fascinated by Microsoft Office and Adobe and Flash MX. When I'm not working, I'm usually dabbling in SEO for friends."

Also very common were Reliance or Tata data cards, which you just plug into your laptop's PCMCIA and then stay connected.

So What Does It All Mean?

What it all boils down to is the fact that women are a lot more tech-savvy than we give them credit for. Some may call our data skewed, though, because we only polled the middle and upper-middle class. We did this because the majority of women in this class have the education and money to be able to purchase tech products and services—and thus the biggest female target audience of manufacturers.

Currently, both software and hardware seem to be heading in the right direction—by just demystifying technology, making it simple to use and understand. Everyday technology, or consumer technology, which is what most manufacturers are focused on, seems to already have piqued the interest of the fairer sex. Down with pink products, we say—quite happily. ☒

robert_smith@thinkdigit.com